

Statement of Purpose

Bachelor of Cybersecurity

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To the Members of the Admissions and Scholarship Committee,

I am Abdulaziz Adel Al-Aqeili, an eighteen-year-old Palestinian student from Dura, Hebron, currently completing my secondary industrial education in the Electrical Applications track (Vocational Competency Pathway) at Dura Industrial Secondary School. I am writing to express my strong motivation to pursue a Bachelor's degree in Cybersecurity at your esteemed institution, and to demonstrate why my unconventional background is not a weakness, but a strategic foundation for success in this field.

THE SPARK: WHY CYBERSECURITY?

My passion for technology is not recent; it is rooted in a long-standing curiosity about how things work from the inside. Over the past three years, I have been the informal "computer repair technician" for my family, classmates, and neighbors. I assembled, disassembled, troubleshooted, and maintained computer hardware long before I ever studied programming. This hands-on engagement with hardware taught me that any system, no matter how well-designed, has vulnerabilities — and that understanding those vulnerabilities is the first step toward securing them.

My specific interest in cybersecurity was ignited through following real-world hacking stories and breach analyses online. These were not just entertainment for me; they were case studies. I began to see patterns: how a single misconfigured timer in an electrical panel can paralyze a whole circuit, just as a single unpatched vulnerability can compromise an entire network. I realized that I wanted to be on the side that finds the flaws before the attackers do — to become a Penetration Tester and Security Analyst.

This interest was further confirmed through a hands-on encounter with malware. While helping repair school devices, I encountered a computer infected with malicious software that had embedded itself deep within the hard drive. While others suggested surface-level fixes, I recognized that the infection was rooted in the system's core — a behavior characteristic of deeply entrenched malware. I prepared a complete fresh operating system installation from my home computer and brought it to school to fully clean the device. This experience was my first real encounter with the mentality of a security analyst: diagnose the root cause, not just the symptoms.

THE PIVOT: FROM ELECTRICITY TO CYBERSECURITY

I entered the Electrical Applications track due to early family encouragement. However, during my studies, I discovered that my true passion lies within the computing and digital security realm. I realized that my practical background in electrical systems gives me a rare competitive advantage in cybersecurity: an understanding of hardware security, embedded systems, and how digital controls interact with real-world equipment. Most applicants come from a purely theoretical academic background. I come from a workshop where I built systems with my hands — and I want to take that hands-on mentality into the digital realm.

To build a programming foundation, I have been actively exploring modern software development through AI-assisted workflows — directing AI coding agents to build personal applications based on my own design ideas, then reviewing, debugging, and refining the generated code. My main project, publicly available on my GitHub profile (github.com/Abd123454), is a comprehensive Arabic-language Life OS progressive web application that I iteratively developed across multiple versions using Next.js 16, React 19, TypeScript, Tailwind CSS v4, and Prisma. The application covers task management, habit tracking, financial budgeting, a Tawjihi study planner tailored to the Palestinian curriculum, health monitoring, and an AI agent assistant — all with full Arabic RTL support. I also built a personal Python-based system administration tool that automates disk cleanup, performance optimization, security auditing, and update management for my own computer — giving me practical exposure to operating system internals, process management, network configuration, and security audit concepts that directly relate to cybersecurity. While I do not yet write production code independently, this experience gave me a foundation in software architecture and a security-aware mindset that I intend to build on formally in your cybersecurity program.

THE CAPSTONE: LESSONS FROM THE ATS PROJECT

My graduation capstone project — designing and building an Automatic Transfer Switch (ATS) panel between two power sources — was the defining experience of my secondary education. Over five months, I independently managed procurement, assembly, wiring, schematic interpretation, and troubleshooting. I implemented an electrical interlock between dual contactors to prevent source paralleling, and calibrated timer modules to ensure current stability. The project required me to think in terms of sequential logic and state-based safety — ensuring that two power sources could never be connected simultaneously, which would cause a catastrophic short circuit. This logic of fail-safe design and interlocking systems is, in essence, the same logic that underpins access control and authentication mechanisms in cybersecurity: preventing unauthorized states and ensuring that the system defaults to safety.

The most formative moment came when a complex system fault persisted for nearly two weeks. Despite moments of frustration, I refused to give up. I systematically deconstructed the problem, re-evaluated my hypotheses, and returned to my instructor with targeted, specific questions. This experience taught me that problem-solving in any technical field — especially in cybersecurity — requires not intelligence

Statement of Purpose (continued)

Abdulaziz Adel Mohammad Al-Aqeili — Bachelor of Cybersecurity

BEYOND THE CLASSROOM: LEADERSHIP AND GLOBAL CITIZENSHIP

My commitment to community and leadership was forged early. I served as President of the Student Discipline Committee at Yasser Arafat Secondary School for three consecutive years (Grades 7 through 9), mediating conflicts, enforcing conduct, and representing the student body. This role taught me responsibility, communication, and the weight of trust.

Furthermore, I have taken the initiative to register in the European Solidarity Corps (ESC, ID: 7519445283524137), the European Union's volunteering and solidarity program. For a student from the West Bank — where such opportunities are structurally limited — this step reflects my ambition to engage with the international community and my readiness for global academic environments.

I also carry significant family responsibility. I accompany my mother to medical appointments and assist with administrative paperwork. These duties have matured me beyond my eighteen years and instilled in me a sense of duty that I carry into every commitment I undertake.

WHY STUDY ABROAD?

I seek to study abroad not merely to earn a degree, but to develop myself academically, socially, and personally. Living and studying in a new cultural environment will challenge my assumptions, broaden my perspective, and force me to rely on myself in ways that staying in my comfort zone never could. I believe that the cross-cultural competence gained through international education is itself a critical skill in cybersecurity — a field where threats are global and collaboration across borders is essential. Additionally, the educational system in Palestine does not currently allow students from the vocational track to pursue university degrees in computer science or cybersecurity domestically. This structural limitation makes studying abroad not merely a preference, but a necessity for someone in my position who seeks to enter this field with a recognized qualification.

WHY YOUR UNIVERSITY?

I am seeking a program that treats cybersecurity as an applied engineering discipline rather than a purely theoretical field — one that pairs foundational coursework in cryptography, network architecture, and operating systems with extensive hands-on practice in penetration testing labs, capture-the-flag exercises, and incident-response simulations. I am particularly drawn to curricula that bridge hardware and software security, because my background in electrical systems gives me a perspective most applicants lack: an understanding of how physical controls, embedded devices, and digital protocols interact under attack. I am not looking for a program that will simply grant me a degree; I am looking for one that will transform my practical intuition into formal expertise, connect me with faculty research and industry partnerships, and challenge me alongside peers who share my commitment to the field. I am confident that an institution with the academic rigor and applied focus I have described will be the ideal environment for me to grow into a capable security professional, and I am ready to contribute my hands-on engineering mentality, my diagnostic perseverance, and my non-traditional perspective to the cohort.

MY FUTURE VISION

Upon graduation, my primary goal is to return to Palestine and contribute to building a robust cybersecurity sector in my country. I aim to work as a Penetration Tester and Security Analyst, helping to protect critical digital infrastructure. However, I remain open to professional opportunities in the country where I study or elsewhere; the cybersecurity field is inherently global, and I am prepared to serve wherever my skills are most needed.

I do not come with a conventional academic background, nor do I claim to be a perfect student. What I offer is more valuable: a proven record of persistence, a practical understanding of how systems interact, a leadership foundation built over years, and an unwavering determination to learn from failure. While I have taken initial steps in self-learning programming basics, I am ready to build on this foundation systematically, and I am confident that my hands-on engineering mentality will allow me to excel in your program.

I respectfully ask the Committee to grant me this opportunity, and I pledge to be a dedicated, hardworking, and contributing member of your academic community.

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09 July 2026

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